xpLosION HISTORICAL DOSSIER & 2026 PREVIEW

University of Birmingham Lions Annual Showcase (2005–2026) · Capital Letters Spell "L-I-O-N"

XPLOSION XXI · 7 NOV 2026

BUCS Division 1 Southern
Bournbrook 3G Pitch, Edgbaston

17 – 3	570 – 130	9 / 20	1st Ever	20 – 14
LIONS ALL-TIME XPLOSION RECORD (85%)	AGGREGATE POINTS (28.5 – 6.5 AVG)	SHUTOUTS PITCHED BY BIRMINGHAM (45%)	ALL-TIME MEETING VS READING KNIGHTS	2026 MODEL PROJECTION (73% LIONS)

🎆 **THIS SATURDAY'S SHOWCASE FIXTURE · SATURDAY, 7 NOVEMBER 2026 · 16:10 GMT**

Reading Knights (0–0) at Birmingham Lions (0–0–1)

Competition: BUCS Division 1 Southern · Venue: Bournbrook Pitch, University of Birmingham · Return Fixture: 06/12/2026 at Reading

ARCHIVE MODEL PROJECTION

Birmingham 20, Reading 14

Birmingham Lions 73% Win Prob · Spread: Lions -6.0

⚡ 10 KEY FACTS & STORYLINES FOR SATURDAY'S GAME (READING KNIGHTS @ BIRMINGHAM LIONS)

1. Matchup Intelligence & Current Form — SATURDAY PREVIEW

- **First-Ever Meeting in 40+ Years:** Despite Birmingham Lions (founded 1989; **181 recorded games, 122–56–3**) and Reading Knights (founded 1985; **137 recorded games, 54–80–3**) being two of the oldest university programs in Britain, Saturday is their **first recorded meeting in archive history**.
- **Reading's Unbeaten Promotion & 6-Game Win Streak:** Reading Knights enter Division 1 Southern riding a **6-game winning streak** after going a perfect **6–0 in 2025–26** (5–0 in Division 2 Southern + an 18–0 Southern Conference Cup triumph over Sussex Saxons), outscoring opponents **122–20**.
- **Reading's Iron Curtain Defense:** Reading have pitched **back-to-back shutouts** (14–0 and 18–0 vs Sussex) and **3 shutouts in their last 4 games**, conceding just **6 total points across their last 16 quarters** of football.
- **Birmingham's Rare Season-Opening Tie:** Birmingham opened 2026–27 on 24 Oct with a defensive **6–6 road tie at Oxford Brookes**—just the **3rd tie in Birmingham's 181-game recorded history**.
- **Rebounding From xpLosION 2025:** Last year (8 Nov 2025), Oxford Brookes handed Birmingham a **6–0 defeat**—the first time the Lions were ever shut out at xpLosION and the lowest-scoring game (6 total pts) in xpLosION history.

2. xpLosION Tradition & All-Time Records — XPLOSION TRIVIA

- **Why "xpLosION" is Capitalised That Way:** Founded in **November 2005** around Guy Fawkes Night, the four capital letters in **xpLosION** deliberately spell out **L-I-O-N**. It is the longest-running single-game campus night showcase in British university football (drawing 1,000–2,500+ spectators with fireworks, pyrotechnics, and cheer/marching bands).
- **Fortress Bournbrook (17–3 All-Time):** Across 20 completed xpLosION games (2005–2025), Birmingham are **17–3 (.850)**, winning the first **11 straight editions (2005–2015)** and another **5 straight from 2019–2024**.
- **Defensive Masterclass:** Birmingham have recorded **9 shutouts in 20 xpLosION games (45%)** and held visitors to 10 points or fewer in **16 of 20 editions (80%)**.
- **Only 3 Visiting Teams Have Ever Won:** Bath Killer Bees (**10–7** in 2016), Swansea Titans (**20–16** in 2018), and Oxford Brookes (**6–0** in 2025)—every single Birmingham defeat at xpLosION has been by 4 points or fewer.
- **The 2024 Anomaly:** In 2024, the off-field xpLosION fireworks/event festivities were cancelled, though the Premier South game vs Cardiff Cobras was still played on 9 Nov 2024 (won **27–6** by Birmingham to complete a 3-peat over Cardiff).

📊 TALE OF THE TAPE: BIRMINGHAM LIONS VS READING KNIGHTS (ARCHIVE COMPARISON)

CATEGORY / METRIC	🦁 BIRMINGHAM LIONS (HOME)	⚔️ READING KNIGHTS (AWAY)
Year Founded / University	1989 · University of Birmingham	1985 · University of Reading
All-Time Recorded Archive Record	**122 – 56 – 3** (.682) across 181 games	**54 – 80 – 3** (.405) across 137 games
All-Time Points For / Against (Shutouts)	4,629 PF / 2,705 PA (**45 Shutouts**)	1,490 PF / 2,172 PA (**24 Shutouts**)
National Championships Won	**5× National Champions** (2005, 2009, 2010, 2013, 2016)	0 National Titles (2025–26 Div 2 South Champions)
2025–26 Season Record & Division	**4 – 4** (BUCS Div 1 South · National Trophy QF)	**6 – 0** (BUCS Div 2 South · Promoted to Div 1)
2026–27 Season Form Entering Saturday	**0 – 0 – 1** (Tied 6–6 at Oxford Brookes on 24 Oct)	**0 – 0** (Season Opener · On 6-game winning streak)
Model Projection (7 Nov 2026)	**Projected Score: 20** (73% Win Probability)	**Projected Score: 14** (27% Win Probability)

📜 COMPLETE ALL-TIME XPLOSION GAME LEDGER (2005–2026 · EDITIONS I–XXI)

ED.	YEAR	DATE	VISITING OPPONENT	SCORE	RES	COMPETITION / DIVISION	HISTORICAL NOTES & ARCHIVE CONTEXT
I	2005	05/11/2005	Tarannau Aberystwyth	26 – 0	W	BCAFL Northern	Inaugural xpLosION showcase on Bournbrook grass pitch (~1,000+ crowd)
II	2006	05/11/2006	Warwick Wolves	43 – 6	W	BCAFL Central	2nd annual bonfire weekend showcase vs local West Midlands rivals
III	2007	10/11/2007	Warwick Wolves	49 – 0	W	BUAFL Central	Largest ever xpLosION winning margin (+49 pts); 2nd shutout in 3 years
IV	2008	08/11/2008	Bath Killer Bees	29 – 0	W	BUAFL Conf 2 South	Launches undefeated 2008–09 National Championship run (College Bowl XXIII)
V	2009	07/11/2009	LMS / Exhibition	34 – 6	W	BUAFL Midlands	5th anniversary showcase; Lions go on to win back-to-back titles (CB XXIV)
VI	2010	06/11/2010	Loughborough Aces	22 – 19	W	BUAFL Midlands (MAC)	Closest xpLosION win (+3 pts); RB Dan Conroy scores decisive TD
VII	2011	05/11/2011	NTU Renegades	25 – 6	W	BUAFL Midlands (MAC)	QB Jonny Glover & RB Dan Conroy lead Lions in front of packed campus crowd
VIII	2012	03/11/2012	Warwick Wolves	48 – 0	W	BUCS Inter-Conf	4th xpLosION shutout; springboard to unbeaten title season (College Bowl XXVII)
IX	2013	03/11/2013	NTU Renegades	16 – 9	W	BUCS Midlands (MAC)	One-score defensive battle gives Birmingham a perfect 9–0 all-time start
X	2014	01/11/2014	Hertfordshire Hurricanes	23 – 0	W	BUCS Premier South	10th anniversary & 1st Premier South xpLosION; 5th historical shutout
XI	2015	07/11/2015	Kingston Cougars	36 – 0	W	BUCS Premier South	Back-to-back xpLosION shutouts en route to 2015–16 National Title (CB XXX)
XII	2016	12/11/2016	Bath Killer Bees	7 – 10	L	BUCS Premier South	First-ever xpLosION defeat, snapping Birmingham's 11-game win streak
XIII	2017	11/11/2017	Portsmouth Destroyers	39 – 14	W	BUCS Premier South	Highest combined scoring xpLosION (53 total pts) as Lions bounce back
XIV	2018	24/11/2018	Swansea Titans	16 – 20	L	BUCS Premier South	Latest calendar xpLosION (24 Nov); only the 2nd defeat in first 14 editions
XV	2019	09/11/2019	Hertfordshire Hurricanes	24 – 0	W	BUCS Premier South	2nd xpLosION shutout over Hertfordshire (47–0 combined across 2014 & 2019)
—	*2020*	*Nov 2020*	*No Season (COVID-19)*	—	—	*BUCS Suspended*	*2020–21 BUCS American Football season cancelled nationwide*
XVI	2021	06/11/2021	Swansea Titans	41 – 0	W	BUCS Div 1 South	Post-pandemic return & emphatic revenge shutout over Swansea
XVII	2022	12/11/2022	Cardiff Cobras	20 – 0	W	BUCS Div 1 South	9th all-time xpLosION shutout; 1st of three straight xpLosION games vs Cardiff
XVIII	2023	04/11/2023	Cardiff Cobras	27 – 17	W	BUCS Premier South	Return to Premier South; Lions defeat Cardiff for 2nd straight xpLosION
XIX	2024	09/11/2024	Cardiff Cobras	27 – 6	W	BUCS Premier South	xpLosION event/festivities cancelled, though fixture was played (3-peat vs Cardiff)
XX	2025	08/11/2025	Oxford Brookes Univ.	0 – 6	L	BUCS Div 1 South	Lowest-scoring xpLosION (6 pts) & first time Birmingham were shut out
XXI	**2026**	**07/11/2026**	**Reading Knights**	**16:10 KO**	**TBD**	**BUCS Div 1 South**	**Inaugural all-time meeting between Birmingham Lions & Reading Knights**

🏆 XPLOSION SUPERLATIVES & FREQUENT OPPONENT BREAKDOWN

Most Frequent Visitors

SERIES RECORDS

- **Warwick Wolves (3×):** Lions 3–0 (2006, 2007, 2012) · Aggregate **140–6**
- **Cardiff Cobras (3×):** Lions 3–0 (2022, 2023, 2024) · Aggregate **74–23**
- **NTU Renegades (2×):** Lions 2–0 (2011, 2013) · Aggregate **41–15**
- **Hertfordshire (2×):** Lions 2–0 (2014, 2019) · Aggregate **47–0**
- **Bath (2×) & Swansea (2×):** Tied 1–1 each

Scoring Superlatives

HIGHS & LOWS

- **Biggest Blowout: 49–0** vs Warwick Wolves (2007) & **48–0** vs Warwick (2012)
- **Highest Total Points: 53 pts** (39–14 vs Portsmouth Destroyers, 2017)
- **Lowest Total Points: 6 pts** (0–6 vs Oxford Brookes, 2025)
- **Closest Win: 22–19** (+3 pts) vs Loughborough Aces (2010)
- **Closest Defeat: 7–10** (-3 pts) vs Bath Killer Bees (2016)

Championship Omens

TITLE SEASONS

- **4 National Titles Won After xpLosION Wins:**
- **2008–09:** Beat Bath 29–0 → Won **College Bowl XXIII** (42–2)
- **2009–10:** Beat LMS 34–6 → Won **College Bowl XXIV** (27–16)
- **2012–13:** Beat Warwick 48–0 → Won **College Bowl XXVII** (17–13)
- **2015–16:** Beat Kingston 36–0 → Won **College Bowl XXX** (19–13)

Sources: BUCS Play, BAFRA Newsflash Archives (2007–2013), Double Coverage Archives & Britball Wiki · Generated 5 Nov 2026